1. Basic facts

Full name and other names

- **Original name: Abul Kalam Ghulam Muhiyuddin (also written Abul Kalam Ghulam Muhiyuddin Ahmed bin Khairuddin Al-Hussaini)** | Encyclopædia Britannica | "Original name: Abul Kalam Ghulam Muhiyuddin"
- **Birth name (chronogram): Firoz Bakht ("Of Exalted Destiny"), known in youth as Muhiyuddin Ahmad** | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "MAULANA ABUL KALAM AZAD (1888–1958) was named Firoz Bakht at birth but was known in his youth as Muhiyuddin Ahmad"
- **Pen name and title: Adopted the pen name "Azad" ("Free"), prefixed with the scholarly title "Maulana" ("Master")** | Encyclopædia Britannica | "He adopted the name Azad (“free”), to which the honorific maulana (a title meaning “master” applied to Islamic scholars) was commonly prefixed."

Born and died

- **Born: 11 November 1888 in Mecca, Hejaz, Ottoman Empire (now Saudi Arabia)** | Constitution of India Archive | "Maulana Abul Kalam Azad was born with the name of Abul Kalam Ghulam Muhiyuddin on November 11th 1888 in Mecca, Saudi Arabia."
- **Died: 22 February 1958 in Delhi, India, at age 69 from a stroke** | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "Died 22 February 1958(1958-02-22) (aged 69) Delhi, India Cause of death Stroke Resting place Jama Masjid, Delhi"

Family, education, work

- **Parents: Son of Maulana Muhammad Khairuddin bin Ahmed Al-Hussaini (an Indian Muslim scholar who moved to Mecca after 1857) and Sheikha Alia bint Mohammad (daughter of Medina scholar Sheikh Mohammad bin Zaher Al-Watri)** | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "His father Muhammad Khairuddin bin Ahmed Al Hussaini wrote twelve books, had thousands of disciples, and claimed noble ancestry, while his mother was Sheikha Alia bint Mohammad"
- **Move from Mecca to Calcutta (Version A — 1890, at age 2):** Moved to Calcutta with his family in 1890 when his father went there to have a broken shin bone treated. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "I was born in Mecca in 1888. In 1890, my father came to Calcutta with the whole family."
- **Move from Mecca to Calcutta (Version B — mid-1890s or after age 10):** Biographer Ian Henderson Douglas notes that other accounts place the family's return to Calcutta in the mid-1890s or after Azad spent his first ten years in Mecca. | Abul Kalam Azad: An Intellectual and Religious Biography (Oxford University Press, 1988) | "His mother was an Arab woman who did not long survive the family's return to India in the mid 1890s, when they settled in Calcutta."
- **Marriage: Married Zulaikha Begum when he was 12 or 13 years old (she died in 1943 while he was imprisoned in Ahmednagar Fort)** | Abul Kalam Azad: An Intellectual and Religious Biography (Oxford University Press, 1988) | "Azad was formally married when he was twelve or thirteen and his wife eight. They lived together, apparently, from 1907

(since in Ghubar-e-Khatir, after her death in 1943, he refers to their thirty-six years of life together)."

- **Education (Home schooling vs. Al-Azhar dispute): Educated at home in Calcutta by his father and private tutors in Persian, Arabic, philosophy, mathematics, and Islamic theology, finishing the traditional *Dars-e-Nizami* course at age 16 (and teaching himself English in secret)** | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "My father had me taught at home, as he did not like to send me to any Madrasa... I was able to complete the course by the time I was sixteen"
- **Work as journalist and author: Edited and published Urdu journals including *Nairang-e-Alam* (1899), *Al-Misbah* (1900), *Lisan-us-Sidq* (1903–1905), *Al-Hilal* (1912–1914), and *Al-Balagh* (1915–1916), and wrote books including *Tarjuman al-Quran*, *Ghubar-e-Khatir*, and *India Wins Freedom*** | Al-Hilal (newspaper) – Wikipedia | "His earliest attempt was Nairang-e-Alam, a poetry periodical published in 1899 when he was 11 years old, followed by Al-Misbah, a current events periodical published in 1900, and Lisan-us Sidq"
- **Work in government: Served as Independent India's first Minister of Education from 15 August 1947 until his death on 22 February 1958** | The Indian Express | "Later in 1947, he was elected as the first education minister of the independent India. He served the post as education minister till 1958."

Groups and organisations they belonged to

- **Bengal revolutionary societies (introduced via Shyam Sunder Chakravarty and Aurobindo Ghosh after 1905)** | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "It was during this period that I came into contact with Shri Shyam Sunder Chakravarty... I remember I met Shri Arabindo Ghosh on two or three occasions."
- **Nadwat ul-Ulama, Lucknow (assisted Shibli Nomani in editing its journal *Al-Nadwa* in 1905–1906)** | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "He then joined Al-Nadwa, the Islamic theological journal of the Nadwatu l-Ulama on Shibli Nomani's invitation."
- **Hizbullah ("Party of God") and Dar ul-Irshad (founded by Azad during the *Al-Hilal* period, c. 1913–1915)** | Abul Kalam Azad: An Intellectual and Religious Biography (Oxford University Press, 1988) | "when Azad left Calcutta for Ranchi, where he was to be interned for three and a half years, not only al-Balagh, but what there was of the Dar ul-Irshad came to an end, and with it, all there ever had been of the Hizbullah."
- **All-India Khilafat Committee (President, 1920) and Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind** | Constitution of India Archive | "He was a brief but active participant in the Khilafat Movement (1920-24), in the midst of which he held the post of the president of the All-India Khilafat Committee."
- **Jamia Millia Islamia (Founding Committee Member, October 1920)** | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "In October 1920, Azad was elected as a member of foundation committee to establish Jamia Millia Islamia at Aligarh in U. P. without taking help from British colonial government."
- **Indian National Congress (President in 1923 and 1940–1946)** | Encyclopædia Britannica | "Azad was president of the Congress Party in 1923 and again in 1940–46"

- **Constituent Assembly of India (Member from the United Provinces, 1946–1950)** | Constitution of India Archive | "Azad was elected to the Constituent Assembly from the United Provinces on a Congress ticket. He was a member of five different Committees"

The 5 to 10 most important events in their life (in date order)

1. **1899–1904 — Boyhood magazines and completing traditional schooling at age 16:** Started a poetry journal (*Nairang-e-Alam*) at age 11 in 1899, edited *Lisan-us-Sidq* at age 15 in 1903, and finished the traditional Islamic curriculum by age 16, nine years earlier than usual. | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "In 1899 at the age of eleven he started publishing a poetical journal Nairang-e-Aalam at Calcutta and was already an editor of a weekly Al-Misbah in 1900."
2. **1905–1908 — Opposed the Partition of Bengal, joined secret revolutionary groups, and travelled abroad:** Rejected the 1905 British partition of Bengal, joined Hindu revolutionary circles in Calcutta through Shyam Sunder Chakravarty, and visited Iraq, Egypt, Syria, Turkey, and France. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "When Shyam Sunder Chakravarty introduced me to other revolutionaries and my new friends found that I was willing to join them, they were greatly surprised."
3. **July 1912 – November 1914 — Published the Urdu weekly *Al-Hilal* in Calcutta:** Launched the illustrated nationalist Urdu weekly *Al-Hilal* ("The Crescent"), whose circulation passed 25,000 before the British government forfeited its press deposit and shut it down in November 1914 under the Press Act. | Al-Hilal (newspaper) – Wikipedia | "At the time, Al-Hilal's peak circulation of over 25,000 marked a record for Urdu journalism... Al-Hilal was finally forcibly shut down by British authorities in November 1914."
4. **November 1915 – January 1920 — Launched *Al-Balagh* and was interned in Ranchi:** Started a second weekly, *Al-Balagh*, in November 1915; in 1916 the British banned the paper, barred him from major provinces under the Defence of India Regulations, and interned him in Ranchi until 1 January 1920. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "He then started another Urdu weekly Al Balagh, also from Calcutta, in November 1915, and this continued to be published, until March 1916 when Azad was externed under the Defence of India Regulations... He was interned in Ranchi until 1 January 1920"
5. **1920–1922 — Joined Mahatma Gandhi in the Khilafat and Non-Cooperation Movements and co-founded Jamia Millia Islamia:** Met Mahatma Gandhi in January 1920, helped establish Jamia Millia Islamia in October 1920, and was jailed in Calcutta from December 1921 to early 1923. | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "In 1921, he started the weekly Paigham which was also banned by December 1921. He along with the editor of Paigham, Abdul Razzak Mahilabadi was arrested by the government and sentenced to one year imprisonment."
6. **September 1923 — Elected youngest President of the Indian National Congress at age 35:** Presided over the special Delhi session of the Congress at age 35 to reconcile the Swarajist and No-Changer factions. | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "In 1923, at an age of 35, he became the youngest person to serve as the President of the Indian National Congress."

7. **1930–1931 — Organised the Dharasana Salt Satyagraha and published Volume I of *Tarjuman al-Quran*:** Helped lead the nonviolent raid on the Dharasana Salt Works during the 1930 Salt Satyagraha, was imprisoned multiple times between 1930 and 1934, and published the first volume of his Urdu commentary on the Quran in 1931. | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "When Gandhi embarked on the Dandi Salt March that inaugurated the Salt Satyagraha in 1930, Azad organised and led the nationalist raid, albeit non-violent on the Dharasana salt works"
8. **1940–1946 — Served as Congress President through World War II and was imprisoned at Ahmednagar Fort (1942–1945):** Elected Congress President at Ramgarh in March 1940, presided over the August 1942 Quit India session in Bombay, was arrested on 9 August 1942 and detained in Ahmednagar Fort for nearly three years (where he wrote *Ghubar-e-Khatir*), and led the Congress talks at the 1945 Simla Conference and 1946 Cabinet Mission. | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "On 7 August 1942 at the Gowalia Tank in Mumbai, Congress president Azad inaugurated the struggle... Just two days later, the British arrested Azad and the entire Congress leadership."
9. **1947–1958 — Delivered the Jama Masjid speech after Partition and served as India's first Education Minister:** Opposed the Partition of India, addressed thousands of fearful Delhi Muslims from the steps of Jama Masjid in October 1947 urging them not to leave India, and served as Minister of Education from 15 August 1947 until his death on 22 February 1958, establishing the first IIT (1951), ICCR (1950), UGC (1953/1956), and the three national academies of arts and letters. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "In October 1947 when the Delhi Muslims were leaving for Pakistan tens of thousands of them, he spoke from the ramparts of Jama Masjid"

2. Story angles (at least 10)

Angle 1: The Eleven-Year-Old Boy Who Ran a Newspaper and Taught Grown-Ups

- **One-line hook:** Before he even turned twelve, young Muhiyuddin was running his own library and poetry magazine in Calcutta—and by fifteen, he was teaching a classroom of students twice his age.
- **Key facts:**
  - Educated strictly at home by his father and specialist tutors in Calcutta, he was running a library, reading room, and debating club before age 12, and launched a poetry magazine called *Nairang-e-Alam* at age 11 in 1899. | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "the precocious Azad was running a library, a reading room, and a debating society before he was twelve... In 1899 at the age of eleven he started publishing a poetical journal Nairang-e-Aalam at Calcutta"
  - While most students took until age 20 or 25 to finish the traditional Islamic course, he completed it at age 16 and taught higher philosophy, logic, and mathematics to 15 students who were much older than he was. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "I was able to complete the course by the time I was sixteen, and my father got together some fifteen students to whom I taught higher philosophy, mathematics and

logic."

- **LEGEND / CONTEMPORARY ANECDOTE:** When the famous Urdu writer Altaf Hussain Hali first met teenage editor "Abul Kalam" at a gathering in Lahore, Hali thought the boy was the editor's young son sent on his father's behalf. | The Times of India | "A story has it that when legendary poet and Sir Syed's biographer Altaf Hussain Hali first met Maulana Azad at a function in Lahore, Azad was so young that Hali mistook him for his father and thought Azad had sent his son on his behalf."

Angle 2: Learning English in Secret with Three Bibles and a Dictionary (PERSONAL MEMORY by Maulana Azad)

- **One-line hook:** Because his strict father believed English books would ruin his faith, teenage Muhiyuddin secretly taught himself to read English by laying three translations of the Bible side by side.
- **Key facts:**
  - His father Maulana Khairuddin distrusted Western education and forbade him from learning English. | Encyclopædia Britannica | "However, he was also influenced by the emphasis that Indian educator Sayyid Ahmad Khan placed on getting a well-rounded education, and he learned English without his father's knowledge."
  - After secretly reading the essays of Sir Syed Ahmed Khan, young Muhiyuddin asked scholar Maulvi Mohammed Yusuf Jafri to teach him the English alphabet from *Peary Churan Sarkar's First Book*. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "He taught me the English alphabet and gave me Peary Churan Sarkar's First Book. As soon as I gained some knowledge of the language, I started to read the Bible."
  - He placed English, Persian, and Urdu Bibles next to each other to figure out the words, then read English newspapers with a dictionary, and chose the pen name "Azad" ("Free") to mark his independence of mind. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "I secured English, Persian and Urdu versions of the book and read them side by side... It was about this time that I decided to adopt the pen name 'Azad' or 'Free'"

Angle 3: Secret Sitar Lessons and Moonlit Music at the Taj Mahal (PERSONAL MEMORY by Maulana Azad)

- **One-line hook:** After a British college principal sneered that young Azad could never understand a book on Indian classical music, Azad secretly practised the sitar for four years—and once played it alone before dawn beside the Taj Mahal.
- **Key facts:**
  - At Khuda Bakhsh's bookshop on Wellesley Street in Calcutta, young Azad picked up *Raag Darpan*, a Persian book on Indian classical music, and the British principal of Calcutta's Madrasa Alia mocked him, saying he would never understand it. | The Times of India | "He became restless also because the British principal of Madrasa Alia in Calcutta had seen Maulana Azad with that book at the bookshop and humiliatingly remarked that “you would not understand it”."
  - Because his father would never allow music at home, Azad arranged secret daily lessons at a friend's house for four to five years with Maseeta Khan, a musician among his father's disciples, until the sitar strings left grooves on his fingers. | The Times of India |

"Finally, Azad chose a friend's house and every day for four-five years Maseeta Khan taught Azad the intricacies of music and musical instruments diligently and surreptitiously... The sitar strings had left their mark on his fingers"

- On an April night in Agra, he waited until just before dawn, carried his sitar to the Taj Mahal facing the Yamuna River, and played in the moonlight. | The Times of India | "He writes he would wait for the hour before dawn, take out his sitar and go to the Taj. Seated near it, facing the Jamuna, under the moonlit night, he would begin a song and play the sitar."

Angle 4: The Outsider Who Joined Bengal's Underground Revolutionaries (PERSONAL MEMORY by Maulana Azad)

- **One-line hook:** In 1905, Bengal's secret anti-British revolutionary clubs refused to let any Muslim inside—until a 17-year-old scholar knocked on their door and talked them into trusting him.
- **Key facts:**
  - When Lord Curzon partitioned Bengal in 1905, Hindu revolutionary groups in Calcutta distrusted Muslims because British officials openly favoured the partition and brought in Muslim police officers to spy on revolutionaries. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "In those days the revolutionary groups were recruited exclusively from the Hindu middle classes. In fact all the revolutionary groups were then actively anti-Muslim."
  - Introduced by revolutionary leader Shyam Sunder Chakravarty (and meeting Aurobindo Ghosh two or three times), Azad Joined one of the secret groups even though its members at first kept him out of their inner meetings. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "When Shyam Sunder Chakravarty introduced me to other revolutionaries and my new friends found that I was willing to join them, they were greatly surprised. At first they did not fully trust me"
  - He argued that Muslims in Egypt, Iran, and Turkey were fighting for freedom too, and helped the revolutionaries open secret branches across Northern India and Bombay. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "within two years of the time that I joined, secret societies were established in several of the important towns of Northern India and Bombay."

Angle 5: The 24-Year-Old Editor Who Shook the British Parliament

- **One-line hook:** At age 24, Azad started an Urdu weekly newspaper in Calcutta with pictures and bold type that grew so popular it was debated inside Britain's House of Commons—before police seized its printing press.
- **Key facts:**
  - In July 1912, 23-year-old Azad set up the Al-Hilal Press in Calcutta and began publishing the Urdu weekly *Al-Hilal* ("The Crescent"), urging Indian Muslims to join Hindus in fighting for complete freedom from British rule. | Al-Hilal (newspaper) – Wikipedia | "The first edition of Al-Hilal was published in Calcutta in 1912... Its politics centered around complete freedom from British rule, with a notable emphasis on the importance of Hindu-Muslim unity."
  - Its circulation passed 25,000 copies (up to 30,000 according to government releases),

setting a record for Urdu journalism, with readers passing around reprinted back issues across India and Afghanistan. | Al-Hilal (newspaper) – Wikipedia | "At the time, Al-Hilal's peak circulation of over 25,000 marked a record for Urdu journalism, and back issues were regularly republished due to high demand."

- In 1915, members of the British House of Commons complained about *Al-Hilal* after it printed an article saying the British Army preferred retreating to fighting; the government fined the paper Rs. 2,000, then Rs. 10,000, and shut it down under the Press Act in November 1914. | Al-Hilal (newspaper) – Wikipedia | "In 1914, Azad was fined Rs. 2000 under the Press Act... Once he had paid the initial fine, he was fined a further Rs. 10,000. Al-Hilal was finally forcibly shut down by British authorities in November 1914."

Angle 6: The Silk Letters and Three and a Half Years of Exile in Ranchi

- **One-line hook:** Banned from entering four provinces and suspected of plotting with secret messages written on yellow silk cloth, Azad was exiled to the small hill town of Ranchi for three and a half years.
- **Key facts:**
  - After *Al-Hilal* was shut down, Azad launched a new weekly, *Al-Balagh* ("The Message"), in November 1915, which lasted five months until the Bengal government expelled him in March 1916. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "He then started another Urdu weekly Al Balagh, also from Calcutta, in November 1915, and this continued to be published, until March 1916 when Azad was externed under the Defence of India Regulations"
  - British intelligence chief C. R. Cleveland linked Azad to the wartime "Silk Letter Conspiracy" (*Tehreek-e-Reshmi Rumal*), in which anti-British plans were written on lengths of silk cloth. | E-Pao (Dr. Syed Ahmed) | "The Silk Letter conspirators in India had thrown in their lot with the Afghans and Turks against the British Government, and a good deal of work in this connection was done by Abul Kalam Azad"
  - With the governments of Bombay, Punjab, Delhi, and the United Provinces banning him from entering their territories, the British interned him in Ranchi (now in Jharkhand) until 1 January 1920. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "The governments of Bombay, Punjab, Delhi and the United Provinces banned his entry, and he went to Bihar. He was interned in Ranchi until 1 January 1920"

Angle 7: The Sparrows Inside Ahmednagar Fort Prison (PERSONAL MEMORY by Maulana Azad)

- **One-line hook:** Locked inside the stone walls of Ahmednagar Fort during World War II, Azad sat so still at his writing table that a flock of wild prison sparrows mistook him for a stone—until his shoulder twitched.
- **Key facts:**
  - Two days after Azad presided over the Quit India session at Gowalia Tank in Bombay on 7 August 1942, British police arrested him and locked him inside Ahmednagar Fort in Maharashtra with other Congress leaders from 1942 to 1945, cutting off outside mail. | Wikipedia – Maulana Azad | "While Gandhi was incarcerated at the Aga Khan Palace in

Pune, Azad and the Congress Working Committee were imprisoned at a fort in Ahmednagar, where they would remain under isolation and intense security"

- Because prisoners were forbidden to mail letters, Azad woke up early every morning and wrote 24 unsent letters to his scholar friend Nawab Habibur Rahman Khan Sherwani, later published in 1946 as *Ghubar-e-Khatir* ("Dust of Memories" / *Sallies of Mind*). | Wikipedia – Ghubar-e-Khatir | "The book is a collection of 24 letters he wrote addressing his close friend, Maulana Habibur Rahman Khan Sherwani. The letters were never sent, as prison regulations did not permit it."
- In those letters, he wrote about the sparrows, crows, nightingales, and garden flowers inside the fort, describing how playful sparrows hopped across his couch while he sat motionless in thought—scattering in surprise when he moved and joked that "a stone may lie on the couch, but occasionally it turns into a human being!" | TPM Journal ("An Analytical Study of Abul Kalam Azad's Ghubar-e-Khatir") | "Suddenly they noticed that this stone had begun to move, and in their surprise, they scattered away. No wonder, I often think to myself, a stone may lie on the couch, but occasionally it turns into a human being!"

Angle 8: Writing With Hot Tea at 3:30 in the Morning (PERSONAL MEMORY by Maulana Azad)

- **One-line hook:** At 3:30 AM inside his prison cell in Ahmednagar Fort, Azad's fountain pen ran dry of ink—so he dipped his nib into his steaming cup of Chinese tea and kept writing.
- **Key facts:**
  - Throughout his imprisonment at Ahmednagar Fort, Azad woke before dawn to brew his own fragrant Chinese jasmine tea and write before the other prisoners woke up. | Wikipedia – Ghubar-e-Khatir | "Maulana Abul Kalam Azad's hypnotic description of his morning routine of brewing and drinking tea is notably remarkable in the book."
  - One morning at 3:30 AM, when his ink ran out and he had no water handy, he poured a little hot tea into his inkpot, dipped his pen nib in the tea, and wrote the rest of the page in tea. | TPM Journal ("An Analytical Study of Abul Kalam Azad's Ghubar-e-Khatir") | "It was half-past three in the morning. When I picked up the pen to write, I realized that the ink was running out... I poured a bit of the tea into the cup, dipped the tip of the pen into it, and began to scribble"

Angle 9: The Speech on the Steps of Jama Masjid That Stopped an Exodus

- **One-line hook:** In October 1947, as thousands of terrified families in Delhi packed their bags to flee to Pakistan, Azad climbed the steps of the Jama Masjid and asked if the minarets of their own city had forgotten them.
- **Key facts:**
  - Azad had opposed the division of India for decades, once declaring that even if an angel descended from heaven to the top of the Qutab Minar offering freedom in 24 hours in exchange for giving up Hindu-Muslim unity, he would refuse it. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "If an angel were to descend from the heavens and proclaim from the heights of Qutab Minar: Discard Hindu-Muslim unity and within 24 hours Swaraj is

yours, I will refuse"

- In October 1947, amid violent Partition riots in Delhi when tens of thousands of Muslims were preparing to leave for Pakistan, Azad stood on the ramparts of the Jama Masjid to address the crowd. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "In October 1947 when the Delhi Muslims were leaving for Pakistan tens of thousands of them, he spoke from the ramparts of Jama Masjid"
- He called out to them not to abandon their homeland, saying: "Behold, the high towers of Jama Masjid are asking you: where have you lost the pages of your history... Go back it is your home, your country....", persuading many families who had packed their luggage to unpack and stay. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "Go back it is your home, your country....” The effect of his speech was dramatic. Those who packed up their baggages to migrate to Pakistan returned home"

Angle 10: Rescuing the Packed Crates of Rare Urdu Books During Partition

- **One-line hook:** During the chaos of Partition in 1947, the secretary of India's main Urdu society packed up its priceless rare books to ship them to Pakistan—until Education Minister Azad stepped in and rescued the crates.
- **Key facts:**
  - During the 1947 Partition riots, Maulvi Abdul Haqq, secretary of the *Anjuman-e-Taraqqi-e-Urdu-e-Hind*, decided to migrate to Pakistan and packed the society's library of rare books to take with him. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "During the partition riots when the 'Anjamane-Tarrqui-Urdu suffered, its Secretary Maulvi Abdul Haqq decided to leave for Pakistan alongwith the books of the Anjaman."
  - As India's new Education Minister, Azad had the packed crates recovered before they could be taken out of the country and granted Rs. 48,000 a month from the Ministry of Education to keep the society alive in India. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "Abdul Haqq had packed the books but Maulana Azad got them retrieved and thus saved a national treasure being lost to Pakistan."

Angle 11: The Sealed Envelope Locked Away for Thirty Years

- **One-line hook:** Right before he died in 1958, Azad locked the uncut pages of his memoir inside two sealed envelopes in Calcutta and New Delhi, with strict orders not to open them for 30 years.
- **Key facts:**
  - Between 1955 and 1957, Azad dictated his political memoir *India Wins Freedom* in Urdu every evening to his secretary and adviser Professor Humayun Kabir, who drafted it in English for Azad to revise chapter by chapter. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "During these last two years or so, I spent on an average an hour or more every evening with Maulana Azad... When I had collected sufficient material for a chapter, I prepared a draft in English"
  - In September 1957, Azad decided that about 30 pages containing his frank personal judgments on fellow leaders and Partition should be withheld until 30 years after his death, and ordered sealed copies locked in the National Library in Calcutta and the

National Archives in New Delhi. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "Maulana Azad decided that some thirty pages of the text dealing with incidents and reflections mainly of a personal character should not be published for the present. He directed that a copy each of the complete text should be deposited under sealed cover"

- After court battles in 1988 on the 30th anniversary of his death, the Delhi High Court ordered the sealed copies opened and handed to the publisher on 29 September 1988—and when Azad died in 1958, he left behind no house or bank account, only a cupboard with cotton *achkans*, a dozen *khadi kurtas*, two pairs of sandals, and thousands of rare books. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "At the time of his death he had neither any property nor any bank account. In his personal almirah were found some cotton 'Achkans'. A dozen 'Khadi Kurtas' and 'pyjama', two pairs of sandals"

Which angle is the big "flagship" story, and why

- **Flagship story: Angle 7 & Angle 8 ("The Sparrows Inside Ahmednagar Fort Prison" and "Writing With Hot Tea at 3:30 in the Morning") paired with Angle 2 ("Learning English in Secret with Three Bibles and a Dictionary").**
- **Why:** Ten-year-old readers immediately connect with concrete, sensory moments: a boy hiding three Bibles and a dictionary to teach himself a forbidden language, and later, as Congress President locked in an ancient fort for three years, sitting so still on his cot that wild sparrows hop over him like a stone while he dips his dry fountain pen into hot tea at 3:30 AM to keep writing. It shows who Azad was—a lifelong reader, writer, and freedom fighter—through small, true details rather than dry speeches.

3. People and places connected

People and groups

- **Maulana Muhammad Khairuddin bin Ahmed Al-Hussaini and Sheikha Alia bint Mohammad:** Azad's parents; his father was a traditional Islamic scholar and Sufi *pir* from Delhi who migrated to Mecca after 1857, and his mother was the daughter of Medina scholar Sheikh Mohammad bin Zaher Al-Watri.
- **Zulaikha Begum:** Azad's wife since boyhood, who died in 1943 while Azad was imprisoned in Ahmednagar Fort.
- **Sir Syed Ahmed Khan and Maulana Shibli Nomani:** Two Muslim scholars whose writings and mentorship inspired young Azad to study modern science and English and to edit the journal *Al-Nadwa* in Lucknow.
- **Maulvi Mohammed Yusuf Jafri:** Oriental studies examiner in Calcutta who secretly taught young Azad the English alphabet.
- **Maseeta Khan:** A Calcutta musician and disciple of Azad's father who secretly taught Azad how to play the sitar at a friend's house for four to five years.
- **Shyam Sunder Chakravarty and Aurobindo Ghosh:** Bengal revolutionary leaders whom young Azad met after the 1905 Partition of Bengal, leading him to join the revolutionary movement.
- **Mustafa Kamil Pasha and the Young Turks:** Egyptian and Turkish nationalists whose followers Azad met during his 1908 travels, inspiring the name and anti-British politics of

his weekly *Al-Hilal*.

- **Mahatma Gandhi, Maulana Mohammad Ali, and Maulana Shaukat Ali:** Leaders with whom Azad worked in the Khilafat and Non-Cooperation Movements starting in 1920; Azad also co-founded Jamia Millia Islamia with Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari and Hakim Ajmal Khan in October 1920.
- **Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel:** Fellow Congress Working Committee leaders imprisoned alongside Azad in Ahmednagar Fort (1942–1945) and later colleagues in Independent India's first Cabinet.
- **Nawab Habibur Rahman Khan Sherwani:** Scholar and friend to whom Azad addressed the 24 unsent prison letters from Ahmednagar Fort that became *Ghubar-e-Khatir*.
- **Professor Humayun Kabir:** Scholar and secretary to whom Azad dictated *India Wins Freedom* in Urdu between 1955 and 1957, and who translated it into English and deposited the complete manuscript under seal in 1958.

Places and events

- **Mecca (Hejaz, Ottoman Empire / Saudi Arabia):** City where Azad was born on 11 November 1888 and lived as a young child.
- **Calcutta (Kolkata):** City where Azad grew up from childhood, secretly learned English and the sitar, and published his newspapers *Lisan-us-Sidq*, *Al-Hilal* (1912–1914), and *Al-Balagh* (1915–1916).
- **Ranchi (Bihar / now Jharkhand):** Hill town where the British interned Azad for three and a half years from 1916 until 1 January 1920.
- **Dharasana Salt Works (Gujarat):** Site of the 1930 nonviolent Salt Satyagraha raid that Azad helped organise after Gandhi's Dandi March.
- **Ramgarh (Bihar / now Jharkhand) and Gowalia Tank Maidan (Bombay / Mumbai):** Where Azad was elected Congress President in 1940 and where he presided over the launch of the Quit India Movement on 7–8 August 1942.
- **Ahmednagar Fort (Maharashtra):** Fort where Azad was imprisoned with the Congress Working Committee from August 1942 to 1945 and wrote the 24 letters of *Ghubar-e-Khatir*.
- **Simla (Shimla):** Hill station where Azad led the Congress delegation at the 1945 Simla Conference with Viceroy Lord Wavell and the 1946 talks with the British Cabinet Mission.
- **Jama Masjid, Delhi:** Historic mosque from whose steps Azad delivered his October 1947 speech urging Delhi's Muslims not to flee to Pakistan, and near which he was buried after his death on 22 February 1958.

4. Disputes, legends and doubts

1. Did Maulana Azad study at Al-Azhar University in Cairo?

- **Version A (Popular biography myth — he studied at Al-Azhar University):** Many government releases and early biographies (starting with Mahadev Desai's 1940 biography and repeated by Jawaharlal Nehru and PIB) state that Azad studied at Al-Azhar University in Cairo as a teenager. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "At 17 Abul Kalam was a trained theologian recognized in the Islamic world. His studies at Al Azhar

University Cairo further deepened his knowledge."

- **Version B (Azad's own denial in *India Wins Freedom* and Oxford biography — he never studied there for a single day):** In *India Wins Freedom*, Azad explicitly corrected Mahadev Desai's mistake, stating that he never studied at Al-Azhar for even a single day and was entirely home-schooled in Calcutta. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "Somehow Mahadev Desai came to the conclusion that I had gone to Egypt to study in al Azhar. The truth is that I was not a student there for a single day."

2. Did Azad actually make his extended 1908 tour of Iraq, Egypt, Syria, Turkey, and France?

- **Version A (Azad's account in *India Wins Freedom* — he toured Iraq, Egypt, Syria, Turkey, and France in 1908):** Azad stated in *India Wins Freedom* (corroborated by French scholar Louis Massignon's recollection of meeting him in Iraq in 1907–1908) that he travelled through Iraq, Egypt, Syria, Turkey, and Paris in 1908 before his father's illness called him home. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "When I visited Cairo in 1908... From Egypt I went to Turkey and France and had intended to go to London. I could not do so, as I received news that my father was ill."
- **Version B (Doubts raised by Sayyid Sulaiman Nadwi and historians Gail Minault & Christian Troll):** In his earlier Urdu memoir *Azad ki Kahani Khud Azad ki Zabani*, Azad gave a timeline of editing newspapers in Calcutta and Amritsar followed by stays in Bhopal and Poona right up to his father's death in August 1908 without mentioning a trip to Egypt or Turkey, leading his colleague Sayyid Sulaiman Nadwi and later historians to question whether he had time to make the 1908 trip at all. | Abul Kalam Azad: An Intellectual and Religious Biography (Oxford University Press, 1988) | "Sayyid Sulaiman Nadwi, in particular, doubts whether Azad made his trip to the Muslim world... Azad's accounts conflict, they cannot both be true, and further research is needed to clear up the discrepancy."

3. How involved was young Azad with Bengal's Hindu revolutionary societies in 1905–1907?

- **Version A (Azad's account — joined a secret group and helped open branches in North India and Bombay):** In *India Wins Freedom*, Azad stated that through Shyam Sunder Chakravarty he joined a Bengal revolutionary group after 1905 and persuaded them to set up secret branches across Northern India and Bombay. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "within two years of the time that I joined, secret societies were established in several of the important towns of Northern India and Bombay."
- **Version B (Historians' assessment of Intelligence Branch records — peripheral contact earlier, deeper links only after 1912):** Historians Ian Henderson Douglas and Rajat Ray note that Calcutta's two main revolutionary groups (*Anushilan Samiti* and *Jugantar*) barred or had almost no Muslim members in 1905–1907, and British Intelligence Branch records show Azad's underground links were much stronger later during the *Al-Hilal* and Khilafat years (1912–1920) than in 1905. | Abul Kalam Azad: An Intellectual and Religious Biography (Oxford University Press, 1988) | "Just how successful Azad was in convincing his revolutionary friends of Muslim bona fides is seriously open to question,

however, for one of the major revolutionary groups, the Anushilan Samiti, specifically barred Muslims"

4. Did Azad join the All-India Muslim League as a boy in 1906?

- **Version A (Government release — enrolled as a boy and left in 1920):** The Press Information Bureau feature states that Azad enrolled in the Muslim League as a boy and left it forever when the League opposed Gandhi's Satyagraha in 1920. | Press Information Bureau, Govt of India | "when Muslim League denounced Gandhiji's Satyagraha, Azad who had enrolled himself in the League when a boy, left the Muslim League forever."
- **Version B (Oxford biography — attended the December 1906 Dhaka founding session as a young newspaper journalist, giving rise to the story):** Biographer Ian Henderson Douglas notes that 18-year-old Azad traveled to Dhaka on 25 December 1906 as the incoming editor of the weekly *Dar al-Saltanat* to cover the founding meeting of the Muslim League on 31 December 1906, which gave rise to the later story that he had joined the League. | Abul Kalam Azad: An Intellectual and Religious Biography (Oxford University Press, 1988) | "The presence of the young newspaper man at this historic meeting would explain the later erroneous story that he had joined the League at its first meeting."

5. When did Azad's family move from Mecca to Calcutta? (1890 vs. mid-1890s vs. age 10)

- **Version A (1890, when he was two years old):** Both *India Wins Freedom* and Wikipedia state that his family moved from Mecca to Calcutta in 1890. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "I was born in Mecca in 1888. In 1890, my father came to Calcutta with the whole family."
- **Version B (Mid-1890s or after spending his first ten years in Mecca):** In the Oxford University Press biography, the editors note the family returned in the mid-1890s, while Douglas notes accounts stating Azad spent the first ten years of his life in Mecca. | Abul Kalam Azad: An Intellectual and Religious Biography (Oxford University Press, 1988) | "He was brought up on stories of his father's exploits in the Hejaz and Constantinople and spent the first ten years of his life in Mecca."

6. Were the sealed pages of *India Wins Freedom* a separate 30-page chapter, or scattered edits across the whole book?

- **Version A (Popular belief and 1958 Preface — a block of about 30 pages withheld by Azad):** In his 1958 preface, Humayun Kabir wrote that Azad decided to withhold "some thirty pages of the text" until 30 years after his death, leading the public to believe there was a single 30-page sealed section. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "When he had the completed text in his hands, Maulana Azad decided that some thirty pages of the text dealing with incidents and reflections mainly of a personal character should not be published for the present."
- **Version B (1988 Publishers' Note after the court opened the sealed envelopes — scattered passages plus editorial changes by Humayun Kabir):** When the Delhi High Court ordered the sealed envelopes in the National Library (Calcutta) and National

Archives (New Delhi) opened on 29 September 1988, the publishers discovered that the missing material was scattered throughout the entire book and included many places where Humayun Kabir had edited or softened the wording. | India Wins Freedom (Orient Longman, 1988) | "On examining the material, it became apparent that the additional matter was not just an extra thirty pages as generally believed but was to be found scattered throughout the text."

5. Pictures

1. File:Abul Kalam Azad 1.jpg | Portrait photograph of Maulana Abul Kalam Azad wearing a cap and spectacles | Date: 1930s | Licence: Public domain (in India, first published more than 60 years ago)
2. File:Jawaharlal Nehru with Mahatma Gandhi and Abul Kalam Azad, Wardha, August 1935.jpg | Jawaharlal Nehru, Mahatma Gandhi, and Maulana Abul Kalam Azad seated together at Wardha | Date: August 1935 (Before the 1950s) | Licence: Public domain (in India)
3. File:Gandhi, Patel and Maulana Azad Sept 1940.jpg | Mahatma Gandhi in conference with Congress President Maulana Azad and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel at an All India Congress Committee (AICC) meeting in Bombay | Date: September 1940 | Licence: Public domain (in India)
4. File:Gandhi with Maulana Azad and Acharya Kripalani 1942.jpg | Mahatma Gandhi with Maulana Abul Kalam Azad and Acharya J. B. Kripalani at the Quit India Congress session in Bombay | Date: August 1942 | Licence: Public domain (in India)
5. File:Jawaharlal Nehru with Sir Stafford Cripps and Maulana Abul Kalam Azad.jpg | Jawaharlal Nehru with British Cabinet Mission member Sir Stafford Cripps and Congress President Maulana Abul Kalam Azad in New Delhi | Date: April 1946 (Before the 1950s) | Licence: Public domain (in India)
6. File:The first Cabinet of independent India.jpg | Group photograph of President Dr. Rajendra Prasad and the Union Cabinet at Government House, New Delhi, showing Maulana Abul Kalam Azad seated fourth from left between Sardar Baldev Singh and Jawaharlal Nehru | Date: 31 January 1950 | Licence: Public domain (in India)
7. File:Maulana Abul Kalam Azad.jpg | Portrait of Maulana Abul Kalam Azad from the National Repository of Open Educational Resources (NROER) | Date: 13 August 2013 (upload/digitisation date of historical portrait) | Licence: Creative Commons Attribution-Share Alike 3.0 Unported (CC BY-SA 3.0)

6. Sources used

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12. Ghubar-e-Khatir — Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia
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